

ELECTRIC CIRCUITS

UNIT REVIEW AFTER LESSON 12

Mixed exam practice from the whole unit, a fix-it log, and a static electricity page for GCSE Physics students.



NAME

CLASS

TEACHER

TARGET GRADE

EQUATION TOOLKIT

You will meet these one at a time. Learn each equation **in words** as well as symbols: your exams may or may not give you an equation sheet, and knowing them by heart makes every question faster.

$$Q = I t$$

Lesson 2

charge flow = current × time

C, A, s

Rearranged: $I = Q \div t$ · $t = Q \div I$

$$E = Q V$$

Lesson 3

energy transferred = charge ×
p.d.

J, C, V

Rearranged: $V = E \div Q$ · $Q = E \div V$

$$V = I R$$

Lesson 4

p.d. = current × resistance

V, A, Ω

Rearranged: $I = V \div R$ · $R = V \div I$

$$R_{\text{total}} = R_1 + R_2$$

Lesson 6

total resistance in series

Ω

Rearranged: (series only)

$$P = V I$$

Lesson 11

power = p.d. × current

W, V, A

Rearranged: $V = P \div I$ · $I = P \div V$

$$P = I^2 R$$

Lesson 11

power = current² × resistance

W, A, Ω

Rearranged: $R = P \div I^2$ · $I = \sqrt{P \div R}$

$$E = P t$$

Lesson 11

energy transferred = power ×
time

J, W, s

Rearranged: $P = E \div t$ · $t = E \div P$

$$V_p I_p = V_s I_s$$

Lesson 12

transformer: power in = power
out (Higher tier)

V, A

Rearranged: $I_s = V_p I_p \div V_s$

FOUR STEPS FOR EVERY CALCULATION

1

Write down what you know, with units. Convert units first (minutes → seconds, kW → W, mA → A).

2

Write the equation you will use, in symbols.

3

Substitute the numbers, then rearrange if needed.

4

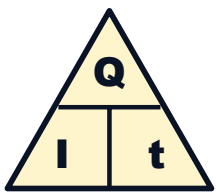
Give the answer with a unit. Ask: is it sensible?

CONVERT	HOW	EXAMPLE
minutes → seconds	× 60	3.0 min = 180 s
hours → seconds	× 3600	2.0 h = 7200 s
milliamps (mA) → amps (A)	÷ 1000	250 mA = 0.25 A
kilowatts (kW) → watts (W) · kilohms (kΩ) → ohms (Ω)	× 1000	2.2 kW = 2200 W
kilovolts (kV) → volts (V)	× 1000	400 kV = 400 000 V

EQUATION TRIANGLES: HELP WITH REARRANGING

- 1 Cover the quantity you want to find.
- 2 The two left **side by side**? **Multiply** them.
- 3 One **above** the other? **Divide** the top by the bottom.

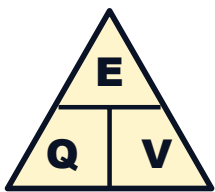
Example: to find I from $Q = I t$, cover I . Q is above t , so $I = Q \div t$. Triangles only help with rearranging: you still need to learn each equation. For $P = I^2 R$, the triangle gives I^2 ; take the square root to find I .



$$Q = I t$$

$$Q = I \times t$$

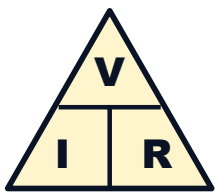
$$I = Q \div t$$

$$t = Q \div I$$


$$E = Q V$$

$$E = Q \times V$$

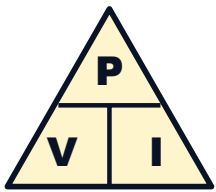
$$Q = E \div V$$

$$V = E \div Q$$


$$V = I R$$

$$V = I \times R$$

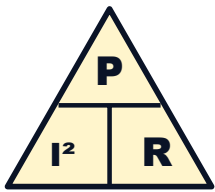
$$I = V \div R$$

$$R = V \div I$$


$$P = V I$$

$$P = V \times I$$

$$V = P \div I$$

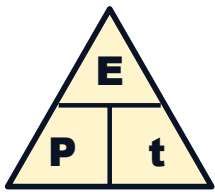
$$I = P \div V$$


$$P = I^2 R$$

$$P = I^2 \times R$$

$$R = P \div I^2$$

$$I^2 = P \div R,$$

$$\text{so } I = \sqrt{(P \div R)}$$


$$E = P t$$

$$E = P \times t$$

$$P = E \div t$$

$$t = E \div P$$

Interactive version: panphy.app/gcsephy/year10phy/unit01/equation-triangles.

UNIT REVIEW

Mixed questions from the whole unit, like a real exam. Try each question without looking back. Then mark it with your teacher's answers and fill in the “fix it” log.



RETRIEVE

EQUATION RECALL CHALLENGE

Cover the toolkit page first.

- 1 Write each equation in symbols. Then give the unit of every quantity in it.

Equation in words	In symbols	Units
charge flow = current $\times$ time		
energy transferred = charge $\times$ p.d.		
p.d. = current $\times$ resistance		
total resistance in series		
power = p.d. $\times$ current		
power = current ² $\times$ resistance		
energy transferred = power $\times$ time		



AQA-STYLE

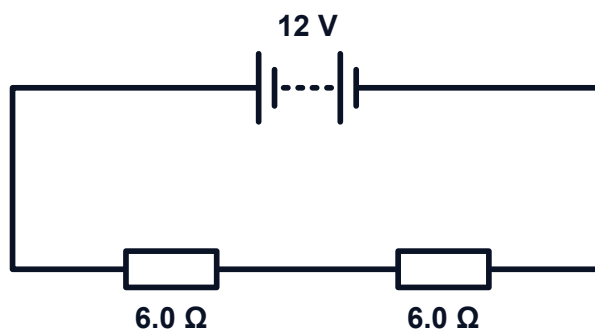
MIXED EXAM PRACTICE

41 marks · about 50 minutes

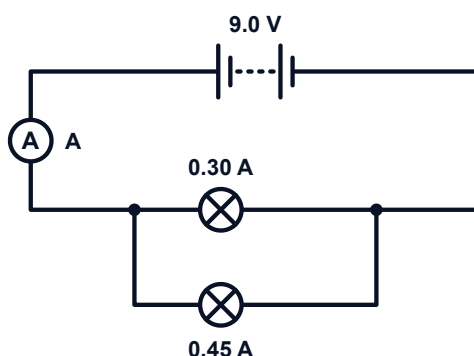
- 2 A current of 0.80 A flows through a lamp for 2.5 minutes. Calculate the charge that flows. **[3 marks]**

- 3 A component transfers 48 J of energy when 8.0 C of charge passes through it. **[3 marks]**
(a) Calculate the p.d. across it. (b) State what this p.d. means.

- 4 Calculate the total resistance, the current, and the p.d. across one resistor. **[4 marks]**

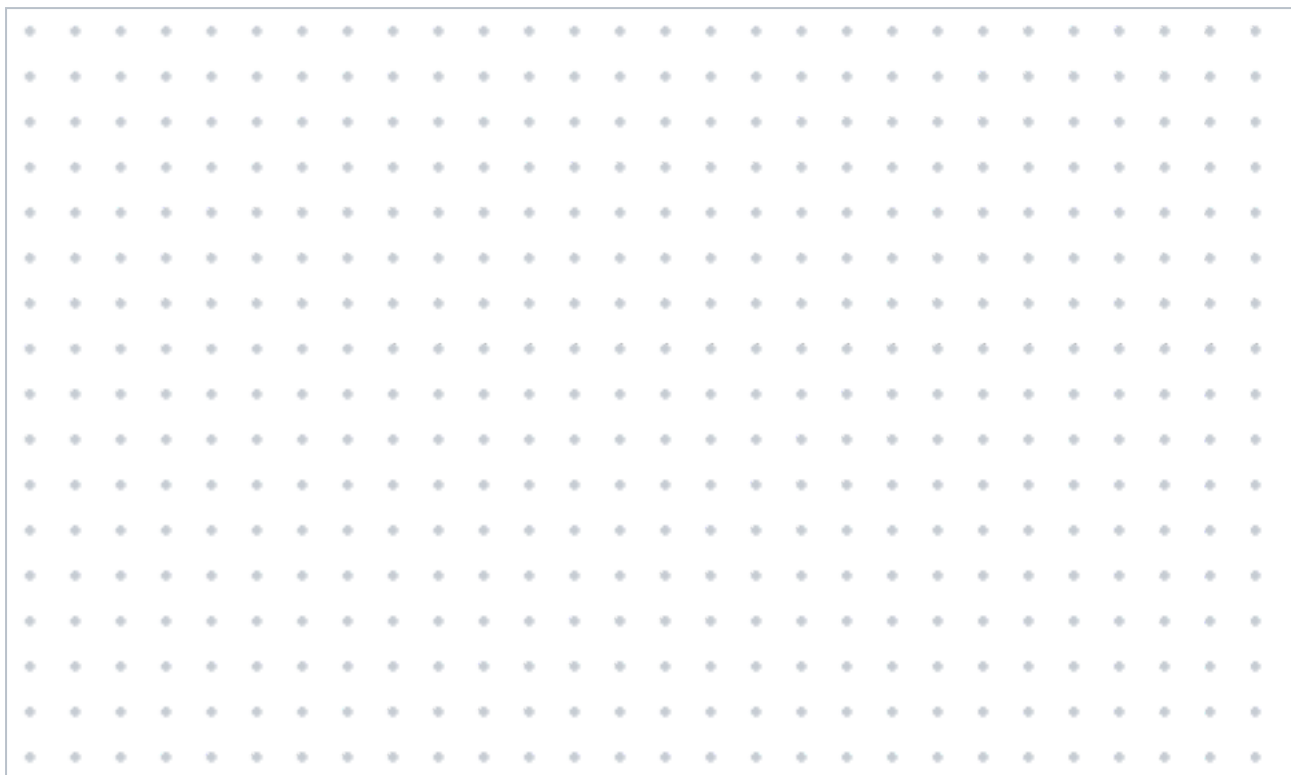


- 5 The lamps are in parallel. State the p.d. across each lamp and the reading on ammeter A. Give reasons. **[3 marks]**



- 6 In the wire-length practical, one point on the graph of resistance against length is well above the line. (a) Suggest two possible causes. (b) What should the student do? **[4 marks]**

- 7 Sketch the I–V graph of a diode. Explain how it differs from the graph of a fixed resistor. **[4 marks]**



- 8 A thermistor is connected in series with an ammeter and a battery. Explain how the ammeter reading changes as the thermistor cools down. **[3 marks]**

- 9 A kettle has a metal case connected to the earth wire. Explain why the earth wire is needed, including the role of the fuse. **[5 marks]**

- 10 A 1.5 kW heater runs on the 230 V mains for 4.0 minutes. Calculate (a) the energy transferred and (b) the current. [5 marks]

- 11 Use the equations $P = VI$ and $P = I^2 R$ to explain why the National Grid transmits electricity at a very high p.d. [4 marks]

- 12 **HIGHER TIER** An ideal step-up transformer has 25 kV and 400 A in the primary coil. The secondary p.d. is 400 kV. Calculate the secondary current. [3 marks]



Q	What went wrong?	The correct physics (or method) is...	Lesson to revisit

EXTENSION: STATIC ELECTRICITY

Only for students taking GCSE Physics (separate science). Combined Science students can skip this page.

When two insulating materials are rubbed together, **electrons** are transferred from one to the other. The one that **gains electrons** becomes **negatively** charged; the one that **loses electrons** is left **positively** charged. Only electrons move, never positive charge.

Like charges repel; unlike charges attract.

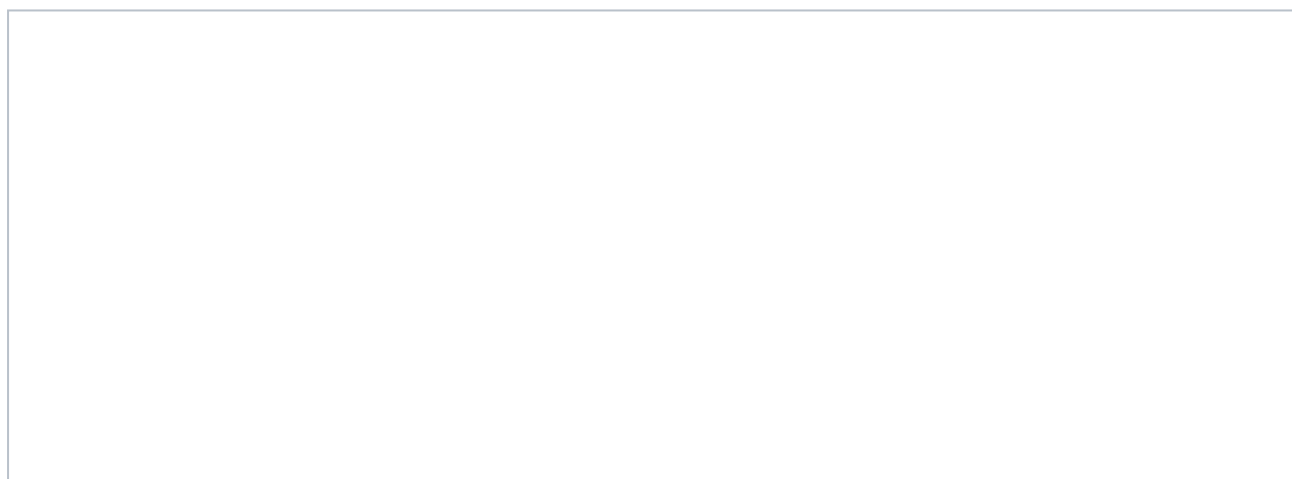
These are non-contact forces: they act without the objects touching.

A charged object creates an **electric field** around it. Another charged object in the field feels a force. The field is **strongest close to the object** and gets weaker further away.

If enough charge builds up, the p.d. between the object and the earthed conductor nearby becomes large enough for charge to jump across the air: a **spark**.

- 1 A plastic rod becomes negatively charged when it is rubbed with a cloth. Which way did the electrons move? What charge is left on the cloth? [2 marks]

- 2 Draw the electric field around an isolated, positively charged sphere. Add arrows, and show where the field is strongest. [3 marks]



- 3 A small negatively charged sphere is moved towards a large positively charged sphere. Explain what happens to the force on the small sphere, without the spheres touching. **[4 marks]**

KEY WORDS

Learn the meaning and spelling. In exams, precise words earn marks: say “p.d. across” and “current through”.

Alternating current (ac) · Current that keeps changing direction. UK mains is ac at 50 Hz.

Ammeter · Measures current. Connected in series.

Ampere (A) · Unit of current. $1\text{ A} = 1\text{ C per second}$.

Anomaly · A result that does not fit the pattern of the others.

Battery · Two or more cells joined together.

Charge (Q) · Carried by particles such as electrons. Unit: coulomb (C).

Circuit breaker · A safety switch that cuts off the current if it gets too large.

Conventional current · The agreed direction of current: from + to –.

Current (I) · The rate of flow of charge.

Diode · Lets current flow in one direction only.

Direct current (dc) · Current that flows in one direction only, e.g. from a cell.

Directly proportional · If one quantity doubles, the other doubles. The graph is a straight line through the origin.

Earth wire · Green and yellow safety wire; carries a current only if there is a fault.

Electron · A tiny negatively charged particle. Free electrons carry the current in metals.

Filament lamp · A lamp with a thin metal filament; its resistance increases as it heats up.

Fuse · A thin wire that melts and breaks the circuit if the current is too large.

I–V characteristic · A graph of current against p.d. for a component.

LDR · Light-dependent resistor: resistance decreases as light intensity increases.

LED · Light-emitting diode: a diode that gives out light.

Live wire · Brown wire at about 230 V; dangerous to touch.

National Grid · The system of cables and transformers linking power stations to consumers.

Neutral wire · Blue wire that completes the circuit; at or close to 0 V.

Ohm (Ω) · Unit of resistance.

Ohmic conductor · Current is directly proportional to p.d. at constant temperature.

Parallel · Components on separate branches. A voltmeter is connected in parallel.

Potential difference (V) · Energy transferred per unit charge between two points. Unit: volt (V).

Power (P) · Energy transferred per second. Unit: watt (W).

Resistance (R) · How much a component opposes the current. Unit: ohm (Ω).

Series · Components connected one after another in a single loop.

Thermistor · Resistance decreases as temperature increases.

Transformer · Changes the size of an alternating p.d. (step-up or step-down).

Volt (V) · Unit of p.d. $1\text{ V} = 1\text{ J per C}$.

Voltmeter · Measures p.d. Connected in parallel, across a component.

PROGRESS TRACKER

Colour one circle for each statement: **red** = not yet, **amber** = getting there, **green** = I can do this without help. Revisit your reds first.

I CAN...	R · A · G
01 · Complete circuits and symbols	
explain why a circuit must be a complete loop	
recognise and draw the symbols for a cell, battery, switch, lamp, resistor and ammeter	
draw a neat circuit diagram using the rules	
connect an ammeter in series	
02 · Current and charge	
describe current as the rate of flow of charge	
calculate charge, current or time using $Q = I t$	
convert minutes to seconds before calculating	
explain why current is not used up in a loop	
03 · Potential difference	
explain p.d. as energy transferred per coulomb	
connect a voltmeter in parallel	
use $E = Q V$ and its rearrangements	
use 'p.d.s add up' in a series loop	
04 · Resistance and $V = I R$	
describe resistance and state its unit	
use $V = I R$ and its rearrangements	
convert mA and k Ω	
decide from data or a graph whether a component is ohmic	
explain why heating increases resistance	
05 · Resistance of a wire	
draw and set up the circuit to find a resistance	
name the independent, dependent and control variables	
plot a graph and draw a line of best fit	

spot an anomaly and suggest a cause

**06 · Series and parallel circuits**

tell series and parallel circuits apart



use the current and p.d. rules in series and parallel



calculate total resistance, current and p.d.s in a series circuit



explain why parallel branches reduce the total resistance

**07 · Resistors in series and parallel**

set up series and parallel combinations with the meters in the right places



calculate total resistance from V and I



explain why series adds and parallel lowers resistance



suggest a specific improvement to a practical

**08 · I–V graphs**

read values from an I–V graph, including negative values



sketch the I–V graphs for a fixed resistor, lamp and diode



calculate resistance at a point



explain why the lamp graph curves

**09 · Investigating I–V characteristics**

set up the I–V circuit and explain each part



take and record readings in both directions



plot an I–V graph with the origin in the middle



describe the extra steps for a diode

**10 · Thermistors, LDRs and sensors**

describe how a thermistor responds to temperature



describe how an LDR responds to light



explain how the current in a sensor circuit changes



choose and justify a sensor for a job

**11 · Power and energy transfer**

describe power as energy transferred per second



I CAN...	R · A · G
use $E = P t$ with unit conversions	  
use $P = V I$ and $P = I^2 R$	  
choose the right equation from the data given	  
12 · Mains, safety and the National Grid	
describe the difference between ac and dc	  
state the UK mains p.d. and frequency	  
name the three wires and their colours and jobs	  
explain how the earth wire and fuse protect a user	  
explain why the grid uses step-up and step-down transformers	  